



Figure 8: Improved Ubuntu installer



Figure 10: Same-old Mandriva installer



Figure 9: Brand-new Kubuntu installer



Figure 11: Redesigned openSUSE installer

com/en/2010_Reviewers_Guide: "The big, obvious, can't-get-away-from-it new feature for 2010 is obviously KDE4 as the default desktop...The point is, we think our implementation is probably the best among this cycle's major distribution crop. So go ahead and compare it with Kubuntu, openSUSE and so on." They can actually say that after making KDE4 look like goo?

Mandriva does still score though. It's the only distro of the three to actually include support for patent-encumbered multimedia codecs, out-of-the-box. Mandriva's Control Centre is another innovation that heavily tips the scale in its favour, and the large amount of software included on the DVD means you don't need an Internet connection for anything except updates. Ditto for one gazillion games, and one quintillion software packages—everything from HPC clusters to mundane office suites and everything in between. Cool, huh? And surprise of surprises—Mandriva, by default, includes Google Gadgets For Linux (GGL) for GNOME users. What? Disable KDE's

widgets by default and give GNOME users GGL? Is this some sort of revenge?

Although GStreamer and Xine plug-ins are available on the DVD, playing a MP4 downloaded from YouTube in Totem on KDE4 (that's the default) got stuck because an AAC codec could not be found. Rather than download free codecs or ask me for the DVD, Codeina insisted I purchase a set of licensed codecs from Fluendo, for 11 Euros. Strange!

Okay—review's over. Time for a shoot-out.

The distro shootout

It's time we pitted these distros against one another. They will be checked on the basis of their download package, install experience, included software (as installed on the discs as extras) and software versions, looks, multimedia support, package managers, configuration centres and customisations, besides unique features. There are no marks or points in each category; it's just *The Good, The Bad and The Ugly*.